BORDERLESS KITCHEN

FREE STARTER PACK

5 Japanese–Italian Sauces *that fix* any dinner.

Five fusion sauces you can make in under ten minutes with things already in your kitchen. Pulled straight from the flavor system behind *Tokyo Meets Tuscany*.

By **Sebastian Dri**

borderlesskitchenseries.com

Sauce is where the borders come down.

You don't need a new cuisine to cook better — you need to notice that the good stuff already overlaps. Miso and brown butter are the same idea. Balsamic and soy are cousins. Parmesan is basically Italy's miso. Here are five sauces that prove it. Keep them; the whole book is built on this.

01

Miso Butter

The one you make when you're too tired to think. Nearly impossible to ruin.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 tbsp white (shiro) miso
- 1 clove garlic, grated
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- Black pepper + a splash of pasta water

METHOD

1. Melt the butter over low heat — don't rush it.
2. Whisk in miso, garlic and soy until smooth.
3. Loosen with a splash of starchy pasta water until glossy.

Best on: pasta, roasted vegetables, seared salmon, rice, udon.

> **Why it works —** Miso and browned butter are both built on deep savory umami. Italy calls it brown butter, Japan calls it miso. Same idea, two passports.

02

Chili–Soy Garlic Oil

Aglio e olio's louder cousin. Heat, garlic, and a little danger.

INGREDIENTS

- 1/3 cup olive oil
- 4 cloves garlic, thinly sliced
- 1 tbsp chili flakes (or chili crisp)
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- Pinch of sugar

METHOD

1. Warm oil and garlic slowly until pale gold. Do not burn it.
2. Off the heat, stir in chili and soy — it'll sizzle.
3. Pinch of sugar to round off the edge.

Best on: spaghetti, noodles, dumplings, fried eggs, grilled meat.

> **Why it works —** Aglio e olio and Asian chili oil are the same three moves: fat, garlic, heat. Soy just does the depth that parmesan usually handles.

03

Umami Tomato

Marinara that went to Tokyo and came back different.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can (14 oz) crushed tomatoes
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1/2 onion, finely diced
- 1 clove garlic
- 1 tsp white miso *or* dashi powder
- Pinch sugar + fresh basil

METHOD

1. Soften onion and garlic in the oil.
2. Add tomatoes and simmer 15 minutes.
3. Stir in miso or dashi at the end; finish with basil.

Best on: pasta, pizza, gnocchi, meatballs, eggs.

> **Why it works —** Italians build depth with anchovy and parmesan; Japan uses dashi and miso. Both are pure umami. Swap the source, keep the soul.

04

Soy–Balsamic Glaze

Sweet, sharp, sticky. The finishing move that tastes expensive.

INGREDIENTS

- 1/4 cup balsamic vinegar
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp honey or mirin
- 1 clove garlic, smashed

METHOD

1. Combine everything in a small pan.
2. Simmer until it coats a spoon, about 5–7 minutes.
3. Fish out the garlic. Done.

Best on: steak, salmon, roasted mushrooms, caprese, tofu.

> **Why it works —** Balsamic and soy are both aged, fermented and dark. Reduce them together and you get a glaze with the complexity of something that took all day.

05

Parmesan–Miso Cream

Alfredo with a passport. Richer, deeper, harder to stop eating.

INGREDIENTS

- 1/2 cup heavy cream
- 1/3 cup grated parmesan
- 1 tsp white miso
- 1 clove garlic, grated
- Black pepper + a scrape of nutmeg

METHOD

1. Warm the cream and garlic gently — don't boil.
2. Off the heat, whisk in parmesan and miso until smooth.
3. Finish with pepper and a tiny grate of nutmeg.

Best on: fettuccine, gnocchi, chicken, cauliflower, baked potatoes.

> **Why it works —** Parmesan is basically Italy's miso: aged, salty, packed with glutamate. Put them together and the savoriness doubles instead of fighting.

THE COOKBOOK

Tokyo Meets Tuscany

30 Japanese–Italian recipes built on the exact logic behind these sauces — Udon Bolognese, Chili Oil Lasagna Roll-Ups, miso-butter everything. Restaurant-level weeknight dinners, minus the restaurant.

Get it on Amazon →

Seoul Meets Mexico City is out now on Amazon.

Gochujang, adobo, kimchi, and birria - the Korean-Mexican collision.

Cook something that shouldn't work. Watch it work anyway.

— Sebastian